

Session 6: Reflecting on the Design of Ephesians 1-3

Key Takeaways

- Paul's mind and heart were shaped by the Hebrew Bible and the temple.
- Biblical literature is full of symmetry and repetition, and this design helps with memorization and meditation.
- Ephesians may have been a letter Paul wrote to all the church communities in the Lycus River valley, starting with the church in Ephesus.

Is Paul's Audience in Ephesus?

Although most modern translations include "to the saints in Ephesus" in the letter's opening ([Eph. 1:1](#)), some early manuscripts do not include the words "in Ephesus" in the phrase. It is possible that Ephesians has been, since its earliest form, intended for broad circulation within the Church.

"The words ἐν Ἐφέσῳ are absent from several important witnesses (P46 & *B* 424c 1739) as well as from manuscripts mentioned by Basil and the text used by Origen. Certain internal features of the letter as well as Marcion's designation of the epistle as 'To the Laodiceans' and the absence in Tertullian and Ephraem of an explicit quotation of the words ἐν Ἐφέσῳ have led many commentators to suggest that the letter was intended as an encyclical, copies being sent to various churches, of which that at Ephesus was chief. Since the letter has been traditionally known as 'To the Ephesians,' and since all witnesses except those mentioned above include the words ἐν Ἐφέσῳ, the Committee decided to retain them, but enclosed within square brackets."

Metzger, Bruce M. (1994). [A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament](#). United Bible Societies. 532.

"The earliest and best New Testament manuscripts omit the phrase 'in Ephesus' from 1:1. It is quite possible, then, that this document was intended as a circular letter and that believers in Ephesus were not the only intended audience. The contents of Ephesians seem to support such a theory. There is very little hint of any specific situations being addressed, or of one concrete community that's envisioned. The exhortations and warning to avoid doctrinal error seem quite general. Furthermore, the text assumes that the recipients have not have direct contact with Paul ([1:15](#); [3:2](#)), suggesting an audience other than, or at least wider than, Ephesus where Paul spent considerable time. It is likely ... that this 'circular' letter became associated with Ephesus because it was intended to circulate throughout the province of Asia, of which Ephesus was the capital and epicenter from which Paul's gospel spread through the province (see [Acts 19:10](#))."

Gorman, Michael (2003). [Apostle of the Crucified Lord: A Theological Introduction to Paul and His Letters](#). Eerdmans. 576.

Ephesus in the Ancient Roman World

Founded around 1000 B.C.E. by Greek settlers, Ephesus rose to prominence as part of the Lydian empire, which founded the city as the home of Artemis of Ephesus. In the Roman era (1st century B.C.E.), it became the capital of the Roman province of Asia under the rule of Caesar Augustus. By Paul's day, it was a center for the cult of Caesar, where the emperor was worshiped as the divine son of the goddess Roma.

Ephesus was a port city (its harbor is now gone because of erosion) and was on all the highways between the eastern regions of the empire and the roads to Greece and Rome.

It was also architecturally impressive, with a huge 10,000-person theater, two large markets, and temples to Apollo, Roma, and Artemis (one of the seven wonders of the ancient world).



[Openstreetmap.org](https://www.openstreetmap.org).

Reflection Question

Do you have any questions or observations about the design of Ephesians 1-3?